



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 06

Vegetables, Grains & Legumes

Treat vegetables, grains, and legumes with the same rigor as protein and your whole cooking improves.

Weeks 10-11 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

1 Blanch, shock, glaze, roast, and puree vegetables.

2 Cook rice, grains, and legumes to correct texture.

3 Build a balanced vegetarian plate.

4 Preserve color, nutrients, and texture.

LESSON 6.1

Blanching, Shocking, and Boiling

Objective: Cook vegetables in water while keeping color and texture.

Key points

- Blanch in heavily salted boiling water, then ice-shock to set color.
- Salt the water 'like the sea' to season vegetables from within.
- Cook green vegetables uncovered to preserve their color.
- Do not crowd the pot; work in batches to keep the water hot.

Technique

- 1 Boil**
Bring a big pot of heavily salted water to a rolling boil.
- 2 Blanch**
Add the vegetable and cook until just crisp-tender.
- 3 Shock**
Plunge into ice water to stop cooking and lock in color.
- 4 Drain**
Drain well before saucing or storing.

LESSON 6.2

Roasting, Sauteing, and Glazing

Objective: Use dry heat and glazing to concentrate vegetable flavor.

Key points

- Roast hot (400-450 deg F) in a single, uncrowded layer.
- Use enough oil and salt; dry surfaces brown, wet ones steam.
- Saute quicker vegetables with movement and high heat.
- Glaze roots in stock, butter, and a little sugar to a shiny coat.

Watch out for

- Crowding the sheet pan so vegetables steam and stay pale.
- Skimping on oil or salt, so nothing caramelizes.
- Stirring roasting vegetables constantly, preventing a crust.

LESSON 6.3

Rice and Grains

Objective: Cook rice and grains to the right texture, including risotto.

Key points

- Most grains cook by absorption at a fixed liquid ratio, then rest.
- Pilaf method: toast the grain in fat first for separate, nutty grains.
- Risotto gets creamy from stirring out starch, not from cream.
- Finish risotto off heat with butter and cheese for gloss.

Technique

- 1 Toast**
For pilaf/risotto, toast the grain in fat until fragrant.
- 2 Add liquid**
Absorption: add it all; risotto: a ladle at a time.
- 3 Cook**
Simmer covered (absorption) or stir constantly (risotto).
- 4 Rest or finish**
Rest absorption grains; mantecare risotto with butter and cheese.

LESSON 6.4

Legumes and Purees

Objective: Cook beans and lentils well and make smooth purees.

Key points

- Soak most dried beans to even the cook; lentils need no soak.
- Salt legumes while cooking - it seasons through and does not toughen them.
- Cook beans until fully creamy inside, not chalky.
- Blend purees with their liquid and fat; season boldly and strain.

Watch out for

- Boiling beans hard, which bursts skins and makes them mushy outside, raw inside.
- Under-seasoning purees, which taste flat after blending.
- Adding acid (tomato, vinegar) early, which can keep beans firm.

Practice & homework

1

Blanch and shock a green vegetable; compare to one boiled to death.

2

Cook a risotto, stirring for proper creaminess without cream.

3

Build a fully vegetarian dinner plate that you would pay for.

Watch & learn (free)



Ethan Chlebowski (the 'why' behind cooking)

<https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski>



Pro Home Cooks (skill-building series)

<https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks>



J. Kenji Lopez-Alt (food science & technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt>



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Next up - Module 07: Proteins I: Poultry & Meat

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM